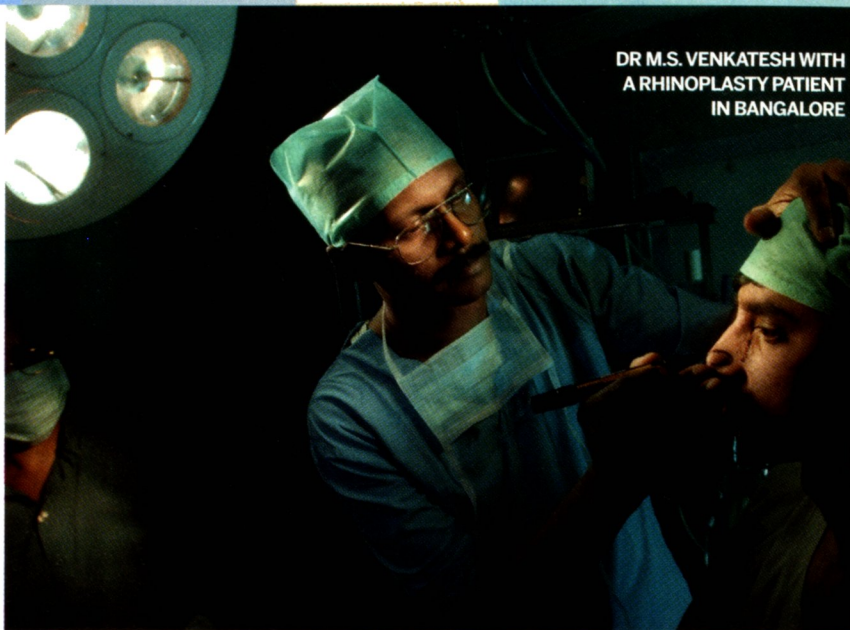


"Previously, the surgeon would access the interior of the nose by making an incision inside the nose, called closed rhinoplasty," says Dhir. Today, surgeon make an incision across the thin strip of tissue that separates the nostrils (open rhinoplasty). "It allows the doctor the least restricted access to lift the skin off the tip of the nose and shape the cartilage precisely."

But plastic surgeons caution that the sophistication of surgical procedures can be disastrous in the hands of unaccredited or unqualified and commercially driven surgeons. "Rhinoplasty is one of the most difficult cosmetic surgeries today," says Pandya. "It's an extremely intricate procedure where every millimetre counts." A bad nose job can lead to asymmetries, dissatisfaction, breathing problems and even a collapse of the nasal frame causing a permanent disability. Bollywood actress, Koena Mitra's botched-up nose job which hit the headlines recently, is a case in point says the man who believes that "there are not more than five plastic surgeons in the country competent enough to do a nose job".

There is risk involved even before one goes up to the OT. With peer pressure and penchant for picture-perfect looks, a large number of aspirants come with psychological baggage. "Very often a plastic surgeon needs to play the role of a psychiatrist," says Gupta. "No surgery is without complication and one has to spend time with patients and understand their psychology." Dhir categorises the type of patients he tries to avoid: "Those who want a nose like a film star, perceive their 'deformity' to be more than what it is, want to change their nose because their part-



DR M.S. VENKATESH WITH
A RHINOPLASTY PATIENT
IN BANGALORE

GIREESH G.V./www.indiatodayimages.com

"Very often a plastic surgeon needs to play the role of a psychiatrist."

DR SURESH GUPTA
*Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, New Delhi
and Delhi Plastic Surgery Clinic*

"Every millimetre counts in rhinoplasty. And a bad nose job can lead to permanent disability."

DR NARENDRA PANDYA
*Jaslok Hospital & Research
Centre, Mumbai*

ners want them to, are seriously depressed, incredibly vain or try to hide earlier case/s of a messy nose job." The bottomline is: a patient has to be realistic and rational. According to plastic surgery literature, the failure rate is 20 per cent while 30 per cent people need revision surgery. "I see a lot of bad nose jobs and it is twice as difficult to correct than a primary nose job," admits Choudhary.

Meantime, the humble nose—often the butt of jokes and rarely taken seriously—is turning out to be a pricey appendage. In every sense of the term. It's now a symbol of agony and ecstasy, of hope and salvation for urban India's upwardly mobile: their chances of marriage and choice of partners, odds of moving up the career ladder or falling face down. If the threshold for undertaking painful procedures has gone down, the ceiling for spending on feeling and looking good has gone up exponentially. So if you want the nose that you deserve, be ready to shell out anything between Rs 20,000 and Rs 1.5 lakh. In one of Nicolai Gogol's short stories, a nose leaves its owner and develops a life of its own. The current national obsession with the nose seems to be walking up the same path.

with Stephen David



Surgery: Aesthetic

Details: Bulkiness and roundness of the tip was thinned and softened. Lateral views show a more graceful profile as the bony and cartilaginous hump/prominence was reduced.

Case study

All case study photos sourced from Delhi Plastic Surgery Clinic